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APRIL 2006



NU QL-711V

too much difference between the monitors in this test.

Ghosting

Ghosting, or streaking, is a major drawback of LCD monitors. It typically occurs during fast-moving scenes in movies, or while playing fast-paced games. This puts a strain on the eyes.

To check for ghosting, we ran four different ghosting screens in DisplayMate, and found that most monitors returned good results, with the exception of the Gigabyte GD-1503B, the NU L511E and the Samsung SyncMaster 540N in the 15-inch category, as also the NU QL-711V in the 17-inch category, which displayed a higher amount of streaking in the colour streaking test.

We also ran an additional test that involved watching a movie clip that showed fast-moving objects, in order to confirm our observations.

Level Shift

In this test, we looked for white and black level shifts, which happen when two adjacent areas differ greatly in contrast. This results in the spillage of the dark colour into the adjacent white area. In this test, most of the LCDs fared well with very little shift visible. Level shift was not noticeable in any of the LCDs at any kind of alarming levels. Level shift, if high, can be a big problem in Photoshop-like applications, where there are often light and dark areas adjacent to each other.

Text-Colour Combination

Here, we checked for how the monitors reproduced coloured fonts on backgrounds of different colours. LCDs have red, green and

blue sub-pixels that make up a pixel. When coloured text, say magenta, is displayed on a grey background, you can easily identify the black space between two magenta dots, making the font look serrated. We checked for the readability of the text and also if the surrounding colour spills off the text.

Of the 15-inchers, the Gigabyte GD-1503B returned the worst results—it showed colour spillage problems with fonts of almost every colour. The NEC AccuSync LCD52V returned the best scores in this category. In the 17-inch category, the CMV and Intex monitors were the worst performers, whereas others that performed better were almost on par. There were not many variations in the LCDs in the 19-inch category—they all did well.

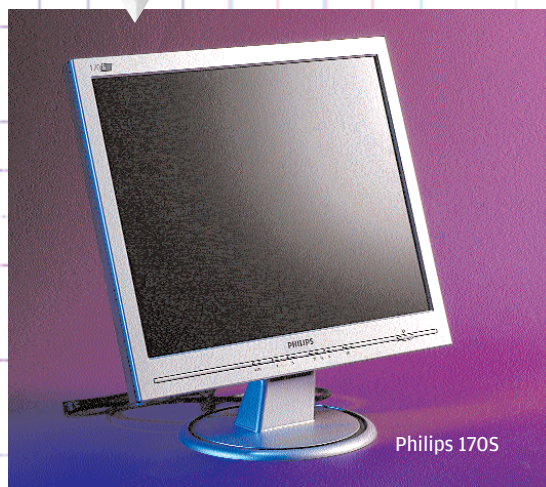
Intensity Levels

In this set of tests, we looked for how well the LCD monitors could display 16, 64 and 256 shades of grey. Most LCD monitors cannot display more than 64 shades correctly; as such, the 64-intensities test with secondary colours and the 256-intensities tests are especially important.

In this, contrast and brightness play an important role—an overly bright screen will not display shades of grey in the light region, and a dark screen will merge shades on the darker side. We found that in the 15-inch category, the BenQ, Gigabyte and the LG fared better than the others. In

the 17-inch category, both the BenQs, the LG, the Philips and all the NEC monitors were found to excel under this test, indicating that these had a better contrast ratio.

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